Media's Effect on Athletes' Mental Health

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KEYWORDS

• Mental health • Traditional media • Social media • Diversity • Females • Athletes

KEY POINTS

- Athletes potentially face punitive measures for not complying with their sports media obligations.
- Compared to the general population, athletes have additional incentives to benefit from social media use.
- Athletes of diverse and minoritized backgrounds may be subject to marginalizing media coverage.
- Although media attention for athletes has various positive impacts, it can also serve as a profound source of stress and lead to negative mental health consequences.
- Understanding the potential negative impact of media on athletes' mental health may lead sports medicine medical staff to create ways to support the athlete's interactions with media through policies and procedures.

INTRODUCTION

In addition to being held as models of physical prowess, elite athletes are also expected to demonstrate mental and emotional "strength." Vulnerability about mental health has historically been stigmatized among competitive athletic culture, due in part to emotions being perceived as a weakness.[1–3] In recent years, sports medicine organizations across the world, including the American Medical Society for Sports Medicine (AMSSM), National Collegiate Athletics Association (NCAA), and the

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International Olympic Committee (IOC) have acknowledged the importance of an athlete's mental health and made efforts to better identify mental health challenges in sport.[2,4–10] Although extensive research demonstrates that participating in sports positively impacts an athletes' mental health,[11–14] both the AMSSM and IOC have published statements acknowledging that the athletic environment has the potential to precipitate or exacerbate mental health issues.[4,5] Media exposure is a significant environmental element that can have a both a positive and negative impact on an athlete's performance.[2]

Media comes in many forms and fundamentally serves as a means of mass communication. Traditional media includes broadcast television, radio, and printed mediums such as newpapers and magazines.[15,16] Compared to newer forms of media, traditional media relies more heavily on objective third party reporters to share information, such as newscasters, radio hosts, or journalists.[17] The emergence of digital media, including social media, enables users to both consume and create content through a variety of formats, including text, photographs, video, and audio.[16,18] Popular social media platforms include Twitter, Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, Reddit, and Snapchat. Each social media platform has its unique features. For instance, Twitter messages are currently limited to 280 characters, and photos and videos shared on Snapchat auto-delete after a set time period. Several social media platforms, such as Instagram and Snapchat, boast appearance-enhancing filters that users can apply to their photos and videos. TikTok is popular for its short-form videos, many of which last less than a minute. Although Facebook and Reddit are structured differently, both platforms provide users the opportunity to join forums based off of their interests.

ATHLETES' TRADITIONAL MEDIA OBLIGATIONS

Athletes may begin to interact with traditional media starting at the high school level and above, although elite-level athletes may begin to interact with media at a younger age, at both local, national, and international levels. Professional athletes interact with traditional media on a regular basis, and most professional sports have agreements with media press organizations.[19] The following is a brief overview of media obligations at each level of play and within the governing bodies of major professional sports.

At the high school level, there are typically no obligations for athletes to interact with the media. However, it is often sought after by players and coaches to generate collegiate and professional interest.[20,21] Some high school teams have policies and procedures in place that require formal media requests to gain sideline media access. To our knowledge, there are no easily identifiable cases in which high school administrators have placed restrictions on high school athlete-media interactions, although this may vary by individual schools or school districts.

At the collegiate level, athletes are viewed by their schools as representatives of their institution and often require administrative approval prior to speaking to journalists or participating in media appearances. A 2020 study performed by the University of Florida College of Journalism and Communications found that 50 of 58 student-athlete handbooks from public universities "explicitly forbade athletes from speaking to journalists without permission from the athletic department."[22] This practice is controversial and viewed by some as the restriction of free speech.[22] Many college and universities provide introductory media training for their athletes.[23]

Professional athletes' media obligations are typically set forth in written player agreements developed jointly by players associations, their respective league, and

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the league's primary sports journalism organization(s).[24–26] In general, professional athletes are required to interact with the traditional media on a regular basis, typically anywhere from 10 to 20 minutes following the conclusion of the game.[19] Some professional sports organizations, such as the National Football League (NFL) prepare athletes by providing media training, including on-set workshops with broadcast networks, and brand management.[24,27]

In the past decade, there have been several high profile cases of athletes who have refused media participation, resulting in fines and, ironically, attention-grabbing news stories. For example, in 2015, Seattle Seahawks star running back Marshawn Lynch was threatened with a $500,000 fine for not participating in the Super Bowl XLIX media day.[28] In response, Lynch gave an interview at the media day, famously repeating, "I'm just here so I won't get fined."[28] In 2021, the NBA fined the Brooklyn Nets and star player Kyrie Irving $35,000 over Irving's "repeated refusal to participate in postgame media availability."[29] At the 2021 French Open, 2nd seed ranked Naomi Osaka announced that she would not participate in required post-match news conferences, citing mental health concerns. She incurred a $15,000 fine and withdrew from the tournament.[30] Similarly, in 2016, Venus Williams was fined $5,000 for skipping a post-match press conference at the Australian Open.[31]

Olympic level athletes are also subject to required interaction with media. To prepare, training courses that provide education regarding media interaction, sponsorship attraction, as well as image and crisis management are required by the International Olympic Committee.[32] Victorious Olympic athletes often participate in press tours following high-profile medal victories to capitalize on fan excitement, maximize visibility immediately following events, and optimize monetary gains in the form of sponsorships or brand collaborations.[33–49] Athletes are expected to follow media rules at both the national and international level regarding freedom of speech and display of an athlete's own values.[50] The IOC Rule 50 guidelines developed by the IOC Athletes' Commission, last updated for the 2020 Tokyo Olympics, gives athletes permission to express their personal and political views during press conferences, interviews, at team meetings, and on digital media platforms in accordance with local laws; players are restricted from voicing these views on the field of play or on the award podium.[50]

ATHLETES AND SOCIAL MEDIA

It is difficult to understate the popularity of social media worldwide, with estimates that of the world's 7.81 billion people, 4.74 billion use social media as of 2022.[51] Of the major social media platforms, Facebook is the largest, with an estimated 2.9 billion users.[51] It is estimated that 90% of Americans interact with social media.[51]

There is a large body of research that explores the associations between social media and mental health in the general population. Since the emergence of social media in the early 2000's, rates of anxiety, depression, and suicidality among all age groups have increased dramatically.[52–55] One systematic review of 13 studies found that time spent on social media, social media activity, social media addiction, and social media investment were all positively correlated with "depression, anxiety, and psychological distress."[56] In addition, there is an alarming link between eating disorders and social media use, which was identified by Facebook's own internal research and leaked to the United States government.[57] Independent research studies align with Facebook's findings, and one meta-analysis found a small but statistically significant relationship between body image disturbance and social media use, with video-based platforms posing an even higher risk.[58] Another study of 996 adolescents found that time spent

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on Instagram was positively correlated with higher Eating Disorder Examination-Questionnaire scores.[3] The relationship between eating disorders and social media use amongst athletes specifically is an area that deserves further investigation and possible intervention.

Compared to the average social media user, athletes have additional incentives to use social media, including self-promotion, recruitment, and industry networking that may ultimately lead to sponsorships and financial support. Athletes also often use their wide reach on social media to express personal beliefs, educate followers, promote social change and social justice, and bring attention to world events. In 2021, the Name, Image and Likeness (NIL) agreement passed, allowing NCAA collegiate athletes to profit off their name, which further motivates athletes to utilize social media for monetary gains.[59,60] While this change may lead to positive financial gains for collegiate athletes, some fear that this added pressure may have harmful long-term effects on one's mental health.[60] There are currently no major studies that specifically address the effect of social media use on the different aspect of an athletes' mental health. Thus, this area will require further investigation, as social media continues to play a prominent role in athletics at all levels.

TRADITIONAL MEDIA COVERAGE OF FEMALE ATHLETES

The number of female athletes participating in sports has increased tremendously over the past decade. At the 2020 Tokyo Olympics and 2022 Beijing Olympics, females made up 48% and 45% of participants, respectively.[33,34] However, media coverage has not reflected this progress, as research has consistently shown that female athletes receive less media coverage compared to their male counterparts at all levels of sports.[34–45] In fact, several longitudinal studies have shown that media coverage of female athletes and women's sport has even declined over the years.[34,37,44,46–49]

Despite females participating in sports in record numbers and exhibiting record setting performances, they continue to experience disproportionate and trivializing media coverage that can negatively impact perceptions of their athleticism.[34] Extensive qualitative literature has demonstrated that coverage of female athletes in sports media often focuses on their attractiveness rather than their athleticism.[43,61–64] Unfortunately, athletes whose coverage focuses on their attractiveness may be perceived as less talented and viewed less favorably compared to athletes whose coverage focuses on their athletic ability.[61]

Substantial research in the area of eating disorders suggests that media exposure to the "thin ideal" is related to increases in disordered eating among the adolescent female population.[61] A smaller body of emerging research evaluates exposure to sports media specifically and its effects on athletes' body image.[65] In one study, researchers surveyed Division 1 female collegiate athletes on their exposures to entertainment and sports media.[65] The study disturbingly found that neither participation in a competitive sport nor sports media exposure mitigated the harmful messages found in entertainment media, with the athletes demonstrating surprisingly high levels of eating disordered behaviors.[65] This research suggests that even indirect interactions with media can have profound negative effects on athletes, especially females.

MEDIA AND ATHLETES OF MINORITIZED BACKGROUNDS

Ethnically & racially diverse athletes are often exposed to interpersonal and institutional racism, which can negatively impact mental health.[66,67] Recognizing that student athletes of minoritized backgrounds endure racial inequities and systemic marginalization placing them at higher risk of poor mental health, the NCAA's Summit

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on Diverse Student-Athlete Mental Health and Well-Being released a consensus statement addressing the mental health needs of student-athletes of color.[67–69] This statement acknowledged that individuals experiencing more stress related to their minority racial identity tend to have significantly more depressive symptoms.[67,70]

Stress experienced by individuals who identify as coming from a minoritized background–whether due to race, sexual identity, sexual orientation, or disability–can be magnified by media coverage. Media can be highly influential in framing ideas about race, on one hand, celebrating the achievements of these individuals, and on the other hand, reinforcing racist, sexist or discriminatory stereotypes.[71] Although media portrayals of individuals from minoritized backgrounds have been shown to influence viewers' perception of these groups,[72] the consequences of racial stereotypes perpetuated by sport media may be underrecognized or under-acknowledged. Given that sport media reaches a large and broad audience, one can argue that it plays an influential and critical role in disseminating, maintaining, or dismantling racial stereotypes.

By analyzing verbal content of traditional sports media, researchers have found differences in sports commentary between athletes of different races or ethnicities.[71] One early study found that football commentators gave white athletes more play-related praise and portrayed them in a more positive light than black athletes.[71,73] Although overtly racist messages have largely disappeared from sport broadcasts, multiple content analysis studies of sports commentary have found that more covert ethnic and racial biases still occur.[71] For instance, a Detroit Tigers television analyst was suspended for mocking Los Angeles Angels player Shohei Ohtani by using an offensive accent while discussing his performance on air.[74]

Furthermore, studies have found that black athletes are often portrayed as 'naturally' athletic, whereas white athletes are often portrayed as being harder-working or equipped with better decision-making skills.[71,75–80]

Although social media platforms enable athletes to interact with their fans, they can also expose athletes, especially athletes of minoritized backgrounds, to online abuse. Online environments provide an anonymity that allows for an abandonment of social restrictions and thus serves as a space for abuse targeted at high-profile individuals, such as athletes.[81] One study analyzing the online abuse of athletes on Facebook and Twitter during the 2015 Wimbledon Tennis Championships found that of the top five seeded athletes, Serena Williams received an overwhelming number of abusive posts.[81] Serena Williams was subject to severe sexualized threats of violence and racially charged hostility,[81] perhaps, because as Adjepong and Carrington explain, 'black sportswomen exist at the intersections of racial, gendered, sexual, and classed oppression'.[82]

However, social media also gives ethnically diverse athletes backgrounds a platform, and possibly power to fight back against and raise awareness about social injustices, although not always free of negative consequences.[83,84] Social media platforms enable athletes to participate in activism and advocacy efforts and spur collective action in response to social injustices.[83,84] Given that high-profile athletes often receive much attention on social media, they can spearhead and bring awareness to important social issues in front of large audiences.[83,84] For instance, in response to the murder of George Floyd, an unarmed Black man by a white police officer during Summer 2020, several NFL players not only utilized their social media platforms to protest police brutality, but also publicly criticized the NFL's delayed and vague response.[83] The day after several NFL athletes participated in a video demanding a statement of support from the NFL, the NFL's Commissioner responded by releasing a statement condemning systematic racism and police brutality.[83]

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MEDIA ATTENTION AND THE MALE ATHLETE

Male athletes generally experience more media exposure and are not immune to the effects of the increased scrutiny. Studies evaluating the media most frequently consumed by male athletes found the outlets consistently portrayed male athletes as "strong, tough, aggressive, and above all, a winner," even willing to compromise long term health for athletic performance.[85] Media portrayals of the male "ideal" body type and gender role expectations are correlated with a rise in the prevalence of eating disorders and body dysmorphic disorders in males; a recent study found that males may represent up to 25% of all patients with eating disorders.[86] Elite male soccer players reported that social media, especially the expression of dissatisfaction with a player or the team by supporters is a powerful source of stress and anxiety.[87] A study of Australian elite athletes showed that experiencing financial hardship and social media abuse were uniquely associated with poorer mental health outcomes in men compared with women athletes.[88]

THE PRESSURES OF MEDIA ATTENTION

Elite athletes cope with a number of unique 'workplace' stressors, including injuries that can prematurely end careers, limited interpersonal support due to schedules, training and relocation, and intense public scrutiny through media.[89] Both traditional and digital media play a significant role in high-level sports, and given widespread access to the internet, even a local story can escalate to national or international media coverage.[90] The combination of intense mental and physical demands can make elite athletes more susceptible to mental health issues.[89,91]

Even professional athletes who have demonstrated considerable success in their sport feel the pressures of media scrutiny. Simone Biles, who was portrayed as the face of USA Gymnastics for the 2020 Tokyo Olympics and favored to win multiple medals, withdrew from the competition due to mental health reasons.[2] She later returned to compete, winning a bronze medal on the balance beam.[2] In one study, researchers interviewed four male elite athletes and six female elite athletes who had won at least two gold medals at separate Olympics or World Championships.[92] This study identified media attention as a source of stress surrounding high-profile events, leading to athletes isolating themselves from reporters to focus on competing; one athlete even contemplated ending his career after he became Olympic champion due to pressure and demands of media.[92] Another study investigated sources of stress experienced by seventeen U.S. national champion figure skaters and found that those who experienced more stress after winning their title attributed it to increased media attention, among other factors.[93] The constant public scrutiny athletes face in their day-to-day life is a prominent source of tension that can be magnified by media attention.[94]

From a team dynamics standpoint, media attention can also be damaging; it has the potential create or fuel problems within a team, most often after difficult losses.[90] In a study published in 2008, researchers interviewed four Norwegian female and four Norwegian male elite wrestlers on their perceptions of media coverage; the wrestlers' described media coverage as often focusing on sensationalism and scandals.[95] When a team has several "star" athletes competing for media attention, the competitive climate may also be exacerbated, sometimes to a team's detriment.[96]

Collegiate student athletes may also face greater pressure to engage in media attention due to the NIL policy change issued by the NCAA in 2021. Previously, student athletes were classified as amateurs, and thus not permitted to monetize their NIL.[97] Although the NIL policy change gives student athletes the potential to achieve

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monetization benefits, the financial incentive may also introduce substantial pressure for student athletes to invest in media attention and build their online presence through social media, possibly without proper media training.[97]

SUMMARY

Media comprises an essential, highly visible, and potentially lucrative component of collegiate, elite, professional and Olympic sports. At the professional and Olympic level, athletes are required by written agreements to engage with the media, ultimately increasing revenue by both increasing interest amongst sports fans and generating new fans. However, disparities among male and female athletes exist in both traditional media coverage and social media visibility. Likewise, discrepancies are apparent in the media coverage of athletes from minoritized or marginalized backgrounds.

Social media has created a far-reaching impact in the world and continues to gain traction. The widespread adoption of social media amongst high school, collegiate, elite, and professional athletes allow for interaction and dialogue between players, fans, and members of traditional media. Athletes who participate in sports less often covered by traditional media have utilized social media to expand their financial opportunities and increase athlete visibility to a much wider audience than what was previously achievable.

In all its forms, media places additional pressure on athletes. Proper interaction with traditional media is a skill that must be learned and developed, and the use of social media also requires thoughtful navigation. Educational and training courses designed to prepare athletes for traditional media interaction and social media use are being offered to athletes at both the collegiate, professional and Olympic levels.[23,24,27,32] Despite this, the challenges media presents to athletes can potentially be detrimental to mental health, as demonstrated by investigational studies. Social media presents different challenges and pressures that also may be harmful to athlete mental health, as evidenced by high-profile athlete commentary. Despite a wealth of studies that assess the effects of social media on the general public, there is a paucity of literature specifically addressing athlete mental health and social media use. This is an area of much needed additional research and may play a unique role in improving the overall well-being of athletes during their time of participation in athletics and beyond.

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